



By Kaveree Bamzai |

Only something of epic proportions could have got actors Aamir Khan and Shah Rukh Khan together post-midnight, even if on neutral territory, at Karan Johar's sixth-floor home in Mumbai's Union Park over pastries and *aloo tikkis*. And it was. Bollywood's loose federation of producers and distributors got together last week to ask for an equal share in the revenue from multiplexes, after years of being at the receiving end of their so-called arbitrary practices: a stop to unethical practices, a halt to differential treatment to differently cast and budgeted films, and ensuring timely payments.

The film industry, in the midst of a winding down from the high cost of talent and acquisitions in the past two years of corporate excess, is in a par-

ticularly delicate phase. Stand-alone distributors have declined from 10-15 in each of the seven territories to a maximum of three, replaced by studios who produce and distribute movies. About 11,000 single screens, once the only hope of theatre-goers, are increasingly being outpaced by multiplexes, with audiences willing to pay higher prices for tickets and treats.

So far, so good. But producers allege that multiplexes, which contribute 40 per cent of total domestic theatrical revenue, have been acting as a cartel, allotting different shares, 48 per cent, 45 per cent, and 42 per cent, for products they dub as A, B, and C category, with the numbers reducing every week. After years of often treating independent distributors in a similar cavalier fashion, producers clearly find themselves in a somewhat unusual position, not only having to fret till the last

minute for multiplexes to sign on the dotted line but also wait for months for them to pay their advances and revenue shares—multiplexes still owe *Ghajini*'s distributor, Indian Films, Rs 22 crore. The producers have a long list of other complaints which includes exemptions on entertainment tax in Punjab not being reflected in ticket prices, tax-free films being charged the same amounts, and a deduction of Indian News Reel of 1 per cent on documentaries despite the official rate being 0.3 per cent. With a stand-off represented by two powerful stars who double as producers, the inelegantly named United Producers' and Distributors' Forum has clearly won the emotional argument, as well as the photo-op war with a packed press conference that was covered as extensively as a prime ministerial address.

The timing is fortuitous. IPL Season